A History of Division

An infographic tracing the timeline of major historical splits and the development of Protestant denominations, from the early church to modern movements.

The Three Foundational Splits

313 AD

Edict of Milan

Emperor Constantine's legalization of Christianity initiated the divergence between the state-aligned Roman imperial church and independent believers over issues of institutional control.

1054 AD

The Great Schism

Theological, political, and cultural disputes split the unified Christian church into the Western (Catholic) and Eastern (Orthodox) branches.

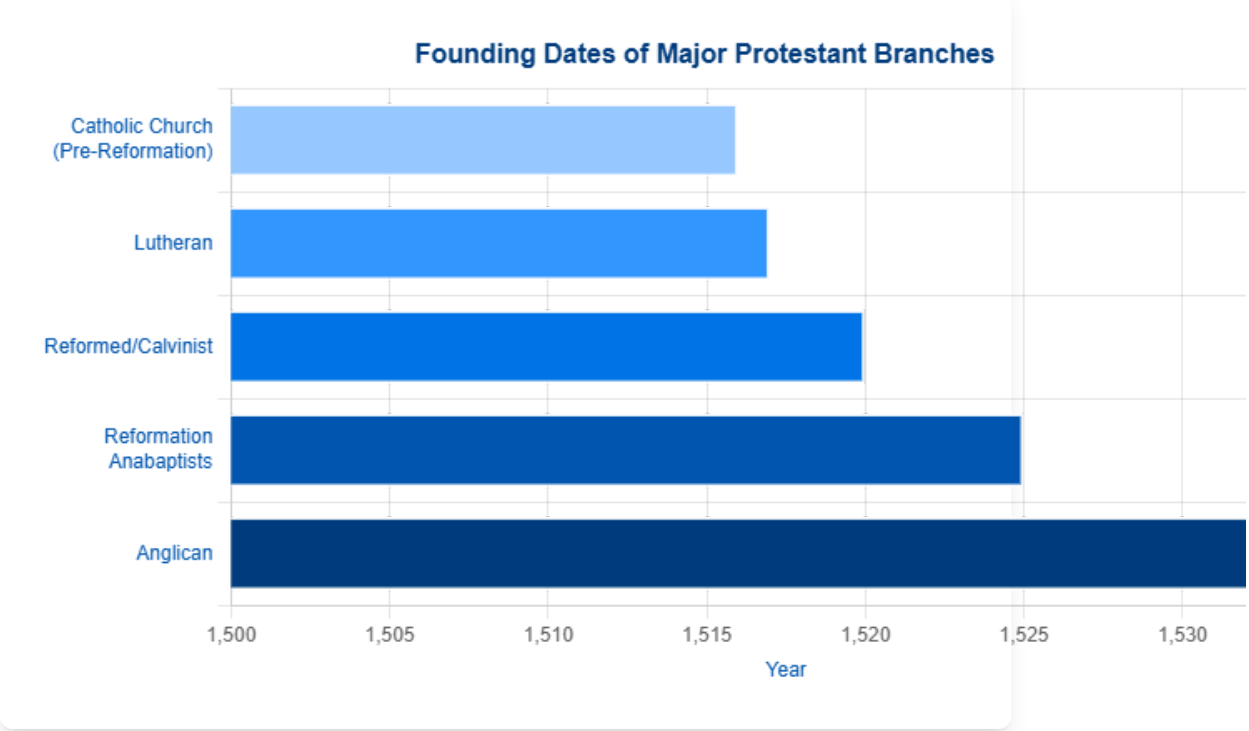
1517 AD

Protestant Reformation

Martin Luther's 95 Theses sparked a movement away from the Catholic Church, championing faith and scripture alone, yet creating new theological debates.

The Protestant Reformation & Its Branches

The Reformation was not a single event but the start of numerous movements. This chart visualizes the emergence of the primary Protestant branches in the 16th century, showing their break from the established Catholic Church.



Later Protestant Denominational Splits

Following the initial Reformation, Protestantism continued to diversify. This timeline highlights key denominational splits from the 17th through the 20th centuries as groups refined their theology and governance.

1600s: Presbyterians & Congregationalists

Splitting from the Reformed/Calvinist branch, these groups diverged on church governance, with Presbyterians favoring elder-led presbyteries and Congregationalists prioritizing local church autonomy.

1700s: Methodists & Quakers

The Church of England saw the Methodist split, led by John Wesley's focus on personal holiness. Quakers emerged separately, emphasizing direct spiritual experience over formal sacraments.

1800s: Adventist & Holiness Movements

The Adventist movement grew from Millerite predictions, while the Holiness movement split from Methodism to promote a "second blessing" of entire sanctification.

1900s: Pentecostal & Charismatic Revivals

The Pentecostal revival, born from the Holiness movement, emphasized baptism of the Holy Spirit. Decades later, the Charismatic renewal spread these practices across many existing denominations.

New Movements Originating From Protestantism

Beyond direct denominational splits, the Protestant focus on scripture and individual interpretation gave rise to entirely new movements with distinct doctrines and holy texts.

Mormon / LDS (1830)

Founded by Joseph Smith, who claimed new divine revelations in the Book of Mormon, seeking to restore primitive Christianity with unique ordinances.

Seventh-day Adventist (1844)

Established by Ellen G. White after the "Great Disappointment," focusing on Saturday Sabbath observance and prophetic teachings.

Jehovah's Witnesses (1870s)

Originating with Charles Taze Russell, this movement emphasizes strict monotheism, the use of "Jehovah" for God, and distinct eschatological views.

The Path to Modern IFB Churches

The lineage of Independent Fundamental Baptist (IFB) churches is traced through a continuous, separate line that emphasizes believer's baptism and church autonomy, distinct from the mainstream Protestant Reformation.

Continuous Anabaptist Tradition (from 33 AD)
Rejects infant baptism & state-church alliances.

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Alignment with Emerging Baptist Churches (1600s)
Maintains biblical inerrancy and independence.

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Solidification of Independent Baptist Churches (1800s)
Rejects liberal theology and sacramentalism.

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Independent Fundamental Baptist (IFB) Churches (20th Century)
Upholds strict fundamentalism, believer's baptism, and local church autonomy.